

# Making a neat concept map instead of just quizzing yourself

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · [cheatgrid.com](https://cheatgrid.com)

A tidy concept map feels like the more careful choice, partly because it never makes you **find out what you don't remember**. Closing your notes and recalling it instead wins, even on a test that asks for the map.

## THE GOAL

You're trying to know the material, not produce a tidy summary of it. Put your notes away and **test your memory** instead.

## CHECKLIST

**You sit down with material you've already read once, ready to spend real study time on it.**

- ☐ Pick one section or topic to test yourself on right now, not the whole chapter at once.
- ☐ Close the notes, textbook, or slides so you can't glance at them while you test yourself.
- ☐ Get a blank sheet of paper or a blank document ready to write on.
- ☐ Set a timer for the attempt, say ten minutes, so it doesn't turn into another read-through.
- ☐ **Write down everything you remember** about the topic, in whatever order it comes to you.
- ☐ If you can't recall something, write a quick note of what's missing and keep going instead of checking your notes.
- ☐ Stop writing the moment the timer ends, even mid-sentence.
- ☐ Open your notes (and any concept map you already made) and check them against what you just wrote.
- ☐ Mark each point you wrote as right, wrong, or missed completely.
- ☐ For anything wrong or missing, **write the correct version** next to it in your own words.
- ☐ Put a short second attempt at this same topic on your calendar a few days from now.
- ☐ If you got almost everything right, mark the topic for a quick review next time instead of a full session.

## THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Trusting that rereading works better than testing yourself is a bet research **keeps proving wrong**.
- 2 Close your notes and write down what you remember. That beats building a neat concept map.
- 3 You don't need a formal quiz to test yourself. Writing from memory is what a large share of retrieval research uses instead.

## Why the tidy version still feels right

### KNOW

Trusting that rereading works better than testing yourself is a bet research **keeps proving wrong**.

Many students expected repeated review to pay off better than testing from memory, and were shown to be wrong. [Source 1](#)

## KNOW

You'd expect the most effective study method to be the most used, but one study found self-testing rated best while ranking only ninth out of eleven strategies students actually used.

So if you're reaching for a highlighter or a fresh page to redraw notes on, that's the popular habit, not the effective habit. [Source 2](#)

## What actually beats it

## DO

Close your notes and write down what you remember. That beats building a neat concept map.

Even on a test that asked students to draw the concept map themselves, the recall group **still scored higher** than the group that built maps. [Source 3](#)

## KNOW

Underlining, highlighting and rereading are rated among the least useful ways to study. Doing them more carefully doesn't fix that: they're unreliable even when done well.

Even careful students find these hard to do consistently: a review of study methods found the gains varied from person to person. [Source 4](#)

## KNOW

Testing yourself on the material and spacing your study sessions out over days are rated the most effective ways to study.

The rating held across many different kinds of students and covered many different kinds of material, not just a narrow task. [Source 4](#)

## What to do with the attempt, the gaps, and the old map

## DO

Getting an answer wrong while testing yourself is not wasted effort. A blank still helps more than no test.

Trying to pull an answer from memory gives you clearer feedback on what you don't know, even when the attempt itself comes up empty. [Source 1](#)

## KNOW

You don't need a formal quiz to test yourself. Writing from memory is what a large share of retrieval research uses instead.

People asked to just write everything they remembered, with no quiz format at all, still learned it and could organize it afterward. [Source 5](#)

## DON'T

Checking your answers matters. If you test yourself and move on without checking them, a wrong guess that's never corrected can settle in as if it were true.

Going back over what you got wrong stops a mistaken guess from getting encoded into memory as if it were correct. [Source 6](#)

## Myths worth retiring

## MYTH

**Building a concept map helps you understand and retain material better than testing yourself on it.**

## ACTUALLY

Tested directly, a concept map **didn't even beat plain rereading**, and retrieval practice beat both. Building the map doesn't buy you better retention. [Source 3](#)

## Sources

1. <http://donaldclarkplanb.blogspot.com/2021/10/roediger-and-karpicke-retrieval.html>
2. <http://www.danielwillingham.com/daniel-willingham-science-and-education-blog/students-should-be-taught-how-to-study>
3. [https://learninglab.psych.purdue.edu/downloads/2011/2011\\_Karpicke\\_Blunt\\_Science.pdf](https://learninglab.psych.purdue.edu/downloads/2011/2011_Karpicke_Blunt_Science.pdf)
4. <https://www.psychologicalscience.org/publications/journals/pspi/learning-techniques.html>
5. <https://www.retrievalpractice.org/strategies/2017/free-recall>
6. <https://ctl.wustl.edu/resources/using-retrieval-practice-to-increase-student-learning/>

## Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Studying that sticks at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)